£1 billion more each year. But are we investing enough in preventing children and young people from reaching crisis in the first place?

The latest analysis from the Local Government Association makes sobering reading. Councils spent £9.5 billion supporting children in care in 2025/26, compared with £6.6 billion in 2022/23.

Behind these figures are children, young people, families and local authorities facing increasingly complex challenges. We cannot ignore the financial pressures, but we must also look at what these figures tell us about the importance of early intervention, prevention and joined-up support.

I firmly believe that we need to invest in people, not simply respond when the system reaches crisis point.
For care-experienced young people, the transition to adulthood can bring significant challenges. Access to stable accommodation, good mental health support, education, skills development, meaningful employment and trusted relationships can make a profound difference to someone's life chances.

Employment is not the answer to every challenge, and it must never be treated as a substitute for the wider support a young person needs. But the right employment and skills support, delivered at the right time and alongside other services, can provide purpose, independence, confidence and a genuine route towards a more secure future.

This is why I believe we should recognise and build on the excellent work taking place through initiatives such as the Youth Guarantee Trailblazers, including:

- Liverpool City Region Combined Authority – bringing partners together to create opportunities for young people facing significant barriers to employment, including those with care experience, through targeted support, training, mentoring and pathways into work.
- Central London Forward – Full Potential – taking a focused approach to supporting care-experienced young people aged 17–25 who are not in education, employment or training. Its emphasis on partnership working and tailored employment and skills support demonstrates the value of designing services around young people's individual circumstances.

These programmes make a real difference because they challenge the traditional approach of expecting people to navigate fragmented systems themselves. They

create opportunities to join up local authorities, employers, skills providers and specialist organisations around the needs and aspirations of the individual.

The challenge now is to learn from these initiatives, understand what works, and embed the most effective approaches into mainstream services rather than allowing innovation to end when a funding programme finishes.

For me, there are three priorities:

1. Prevention must come first. Identify needs earlier, strengthen family and community support, and intervene before challenges escalate into crisis.
2. Employment and skills must be part of the solution. Provide personalised, sustained support that connects young people to education, training, employers and good-quality work, with the wraparound support needed to sustain progress.
3. Measure success by the difference we make to people's lives. Not simply the number of referrals, engagements or job starts, but whether young people achieve stability, develop confidence, sustain employment and have greater control over their futures.

Ultimately, this is about more than budgets, programmes or performance targets. It is about the kind of society we want to build and the opportunities we are prepared to create for young people who have already faced significant adversity.

We cannot eliminate every challenge, but we can do much more to ensure that a young person's care experience does not determine their future.

Prevention, partnership and opportunity must sit at the heart of our approach. I would welcome a national commitment to learning from the Youth Guarantee Trailblazers, scaling what works and ensuring that care-experienced young people are supported to achieve their ambitions.

Find the article here:

Costs of supporting children in care rise by £1 billion a year | Local Government Association